



CUPPING

The ancient practice of cupping was once widely believed to help cure diseases by encouraging blood flow. Small cups are heated and placed on the skin. As the air inside a cup cools, it contracts, sucking up an area of skin and drawing blood to the surface. Red rings and sometimes bruises are left afterward.



A HOLE IN THE HEAD

Stone age people believed that diseases were caused by evil spirits. The cure, they thought, was to drill a hole in the skull to release the spirit—a technique called trepanning. Some prehistoric skulls found by archaeologists have as many as 40 holes drilled in them.

BARBER SURGEONS

In medieval Europe, all operations from tooth extraction to mending broken arms were performed by barbers. Surgery was often deadly since barbers had little idea how to stop wounds from getting infected. And patients had to stay awake during treatment since general anesthetics didn't exist.



▲ BLOODSUCKERS

The Roman Emperor Galerius was treated with leeches to cure an "abominable stench."



BLOODLETTING

Removing blood, or bloodletting, was a very common medical practice for centuries. It was thought to put body fluids back into balance. Blood was drawn by cutting the skin, by piercing veins and arteries, or by using bloodsucking leeches.

MUD BATHS

Bathing in pools of mud, hot springs, or mineral water has long been a popular treatment for joint pain (arthritis), skin complaints, and other conditions. Even today, people travel great distances to visit famous spa towns and "take the waters."

